

fridayReview

THE HINDU

A tale of modern society
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In her own space
How Suman Kalyanpur struck a distinct note in the Hindi film music world **p4**



ANDREW LLOYD WEBBER'S ICONIC WORK
CATS, first staged at London's West End, comes to India **p4**

S.P. Balasubrahmanyam, whose 80th birth anniversary just passed, was an untrained genius who carried infinite emotion in his singing

Vignettes of a voice

Bala Shankar

For over five decades, film music fans in South India shared a deep affection for a voice that permeated their homes and hearts like no other. SPB, as he is popularly known, would have turned 80 this week (June 4). It is no surprise that celebrations are being held everywhere, even though we lost his physical presence a few years ago. In fact, it still feels surreal to speak of the legend in the past tense.

An engineering student with no formal training in music, SPB used to perform at film music shows, hoping for a breakthrough as a playback singer. A chance encounter with two

legends – K.V. Mahadevan and M.S. Viswanathan – changed his destiny. He recorded 'Ayiram nilave vaa' (*Adimai Penn*) for K.V. Mahadevan and 'Iyarkkai ennum ilaya kanni' (*Shanthi Nilayam*) for nonpareil M.S. Viswanathan in the late 1960s. The two hit songs – sung for top stars MGR and Gemini Ganesan – ensured that he never had to look back. It was a refreshingly unique voice – breezy, youthful, melodious, hummable and yet not high-voltage – as was the norm then. 'Ayiram nilave vaa' became the go-to song for aspiring singers at competitions then. So, SPB's arrival was as effortless as his singing style.

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When her struggle transforms into a tale of victory.

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The world is brimming with stories of courage and resilience. While many go unheard and unsung, a few do make it to the spotlight in the form of a book, a movie, or even a play. One such story is *Ananya - A Journey beyond Imagination* – an inspiring journey of an ordinary girl with extraordinary dreams.

Ananya is a brilliant student and achiever, known for her confidence, charm, and beauty. Her future looks bright – with a promising career and an engagement to a wealthy man who falls in love with her. But a tragic accident turns her world upside down. Hopes dim, relationships crumble, and the people who once cheered her now begin to see her as a burden.

The play, written and directed by Pratap Phad and produced by Sejal Dipak Painter, features well-known television, film and theatre actor Shweta Gulati in the titular role, aptly supported by Chitrashi Rawat, Atul Tiwari, Mustafa Burmawala, Savant Singh Premi, and Siddharth Bodke.

Ananya, says Pratap, is inspired by “a real life story. A few years ago, I read a Marathi book that had two stories of women – one about a cancer survivor, the other about a girl like Ananya. I took the premise of Ananya from the book, fictionalised it and wrote the play. I wanted to tell the story of this girl, who is living somewhere in the world, and wanted to tell it in my own way,” says Pratap.

Though set against the backdrop of a finely detailed stage, the play attempts to

Triumph of the spirit

Pratap Phad’s play, *Ananya*, inspired by a real life story, to be staged in Chennai on June 7



“Instead, it brims with laughter, sarcasm and moments of cheer.” He also shares that the audience has applauded the scenes where the protagonist overcomes the smallest challenges using her feet – working on a laptop, brushing her teeth or learning to fold a blanket with her feet. And one particular scene that unflinchingly draws thunderous applause, says Pratap, is the one where Ananya crawls across the floor, using her feet to release the fire extinguisher to put out a blaze in her kitchen.

Just like its protagonist, the play itself has had a journey of its own. First staged in 2009-2010 as a one-act play, it grew into a full-length Marathi stage production in 2017. The commercial success of the Marathi play paved the way for *Ananya* to be made into a Marathi film in 2022 with the same name. “A leading Marathi film producer asked me if I could adapt the story for the big screen. For me, it meant the narrative could inspire more people,” shares Pratap, who was later asked to adapt the same into a Hindi play. This, he says, was a challenge, as he had to train a new set of

tale of triumph.”

Ananya, reveals the director, neither leans into sentimentality nor collapses into being a tear-jerker.



Following its commercial success, *Ananya* was adapted into a Marathi film and a Hindi play.

PRATAP PHAD

Hindi-speaking actors for the production and praises Shweta for all the hard work she has put in for the role.

The production, adds Pratap, also pans into a digital spectacle, especially to depict the wedding of Ananya in the ending, “which is projected on a screen”. But, wouldn’t that break the fourth wall of theatre, distracting the audience from pure theatrical elements of making do with what you have, transforming limitation into imagination?

Pratap agrees, “Some cinematic elements had to be brought in keeping in mind the commercial aspects of the play too.” Yet, he insists the emotional purity of the story remains intact. “Ananya’s journey could have ended with her passing her exam with distinction, or simply at the point where she gets a job. But, I felt her chance at love and marriage would encompass the fullness of life. And with such an emotional story, one has to keep the mood a little light, else the narrative can turn morose.”

For a theatre director, it is always a tightrope walk – balancing pure theatrical elements and the lure of the commercial. The challenge lies in enjoying creative freedom while keeping an eye on what ensures a play’s success.

Shweta has been hailed for her portrayal of Ananya. “It took several months of demanding physical training that left me with elbow strain. Yet it has been worth it. *Ananya* is one of the most difficult and rewarding roles of my career,” she says.

The play, in Hindi, will be staged at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall, on June 7, 5 p.m. Tickets on BookMyShow.

Finding harmony in discord

Tamil play *Mental Mandhil* explored the quirks, conflicts and quiet truths of married life

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Tamil theatre group thRee entertains’ *Mental Manadhil* (concept by M.V. Bhaskar; story and dialogues by V. Sreevathson; direction by M.V. Bhaskar), inaugurated in Kolkata and recently staged at Krishna Gana Sabha, takes a humorous look at modern matrimony. Sundar (Prabhu) and Divya (Priya Kannamma) are in love. Sundar is determined not to become a dominating husband like his father, Mohan Ram (K. Subramaniam). Divya, however, wants her husband to be like her father, Subbu (M.V. Bhaskar). In Subbu’s household, only his wife’s opinion matters, and Subbu pretends that her views are his own to keep her happy. Divya believes her parents are an ideal couple, but the play reveals that marriages are not always what they appear to be on the surface.

Mohan Ram isn’t dominating and his wife Padma (Lavanya Venugopal) is anything but meek. They are happy in their marriage,

while Subbu remains miserable. Divya, a replica of her mother, expects Sundar to agree with everything she says, because she feels that a couple must share identical interests. In the early stages of their romance, Sundar does everything she wants. But eventually feels he cannot take it anymore and calls off the wedding. Padma helps Divya understand that a successful marriage doesn’t require identical tastes, but a shared sense of humour and a lot of patience.

The dialogue was sharp and relatable. As someone once defined it, marriage is the peaceful coexistence of two nervous systems, and the operative word here is co-existence. It implies that there will be tiffs and differences of opinion, but that conflicts will eventually be resolved. The play rejected the myth that soulmates must be mirror images. The modern idea of matrimony as two souls living in perfect harmony is far from reality. After all, what is a marriage without some friction to add spice? The cast’s performances drove home the joys of an imperfect marriage.



PHOTO: M. SRINATH

Concert series

Under the auspices of Madhuradhwani, the following programmes will take place at Arkay Convention Center, Mylapore. Schedule: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Mysore Vasudevachar remembrance day concert will be by O.S. Arun. Tomorrow, 5 p.m.: Bhavya Hari, Vidya Kalyanaraman and Brindha Manickavasakan will render Kandapuram kritis of Ramaswamy Sivan. The concert is organised, as part of the 182nd jayanti of Maha Vaidyanatha Sivan, by Sri Guhadasa Trust. June 7, 9.30 a.m.: Viswa Kala Sangama presents Vishal Moghe’s vocal concert as part of the Morning Raga series. Niranjan Hegde on the harmonium and Sumith Nail on the tabla are the accompanists; and 6.15 p.m.: H.K. Venkatram. June 9, 6.15 p.m.: Veena Venkatramani (veena). June 10, 6.15 p.m.: Anirudh Subramanian. June 11, 6.15 p.m.: Aadithyadev V. Punnayurkulam.

Holding a mirror to society’s truths

Through movement, music and powerful performances, *Pataliputhram* explores universal themes of migration, globalisation and systemic inequality

Chitradeepa Anantharam
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Have you ever wondered what relentless physical labour does to the human body and mind? What does it mean to push beyond sexuality, gender, pain and exhaustion in the struggle to survive? When hunger alone drives a person forward, what does work become – drudgery, prayer, meditation, or simply a means to stay alive? Such metaphysical questions lie at the heart of Gnana Rajasekaran’s *Pataliputhram*, directed by K.R. Rajaravivarma, professor, department of performing arts, Pondicherry University . Premiered recently at



Driving home a message
Koothu-p-Pattarai’s *Pataliputhram*.
PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Koothu-p-Pattarai, the play explores universal themes of migration, globalisation and systemic inequality shaped by caste and country of origin. Through recurring imagery – *yejamaan* (the master or organisation), *saattai* (the whip, or conditioning), *satti* (the mud pot, transformed into a globally marketable product), and the *adimaigal* (slaves, labourers across sectors) – the Koothu-p-pattarai production examines alienation, the absurdity of daily existence and the struggle for

individual identity.

These are realities humanity has witnessed throughout history and continues to confront in the present. The labourers in *Pataliputhram* toil relentlessly for *coolis* (wages) and *soru* (food), under the monstrous and watchful gaze of the *yejamaan*, who wields the whip and demands the production of more mud pots each day to feed the market’s endless appetite. Yet, with every step towards awareness, the labourers encounter not emancipation but turmoil; not clarity, but confusion. The play suggests that nothing can truly liberate them except self-awareness. The play concludes on a haunting note: that even future generations may not be spared this cycle. Blending song and dance,

the performers deliver a compelling piece of movement theatre that communicates its message with clarity. Rajaravivarma’s direction transforms labour into theatrical language.

While the entire cast contributed to the overall ethos of the play, particularly noteworthy were A. Ajith Kumar, S. Riyazini, L. Premkumar – who also handled the lighting – M. Ramesh for his soulful rendition of the songs, and E. Karthick as the *sattaikaran*, who was also responsible for the costume design.

In an age shaped by displacement, exploitation and widening inequalities, *Pataliputhram* feels less like theatre and more like an urgent social mirror.

Narendra Kusnur

On his maiden visit to India, British theatre personality Matt Krzan serves as the resident director of the international production of Andrew Lloyd Webber's musical, *Cats*, which will be staged at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai.

“*Cats* is unique because it is a completely sung-through show and is so intertwined with dance. We are taking the audience to a different world where humans are cats prowling a junkyard. It is a magical show as it allows you to believe and be transported,” says Matt.

Cats, which premiered in London's West End in 1981, is based on T.S. Eliot's 1939 poetry collection *Old Possum's Book of Practical Cats*. First directed by Sir Trevor Nunn, the musical traces the tale of a tribe of cats called Jellicles.

Basically an actor, Matt has had a long association with *Cats* in multiple capacities. Though *Joseph and the Technicolor Dreamcoat* was the first Lloyd Webber show that Matt saw live, he would watch *Cats* on video over and over again, till he saw a stage performance when he was 17.

Professionally, he was first involved with *Cats* in 2004. “I got the job while I was still in college. I was originally a swing, which means you cover numerous roles and go on stage when someone is injured or on holiday. I then joined the cast again two years later and played Macavity, touring the U.K. and Italy. I went on to play Munkustrap at the London Palladium which was a dream come true. I got to work closely with Sir Trevor Nunn, the director, and Dame Gillian Lynne, the choreographer,” he says.

Subsequently, Matt took over as dance captain. “That means I had to maintain the standard and quality of the



On its India premiere, Matt Krzan, resident director of Andrew Lloyd Webber's musical, talks about his association with it in multiple capacities

dance within the show. I toured the U.K. and other countries. A few years later, I joined the South Korea cast, simultaneously playing the role of Munkustrap and leading the show as resident director.”

Composed by Lloyd Webber, the production is renowned for its visionary stagecraft and groundbreaking artistry. John Napier's oversized junkyard set transforms the stage into a fantastical playground, while Lynne's choreography and Nunn's direction create a richly-immersive theatrical

world. The score includes the songs ‘Old Deuteronomy’, ‘Macavity: The Mystery Cat’, ‘The Jellicle Ball’ and the hugely popular ‘Memory’. At the Mumbai shows, Peter McCarthy will be the musical supervisor.

Matt says that the cast of the production was put together through an extensive audition process where they danced a section of the show first and then sang a song of their own choice. He adds, “Every character in the show has an identity of its own and our director, Chrissie

Cartwright, has a talent for spotting the performer and casting them in the right role.”

This particular cast was assembled last October. “They performed in South Africa for over two months and had a short break. We will have rehearsals before we open back in Mumbai.”

Matt points out that since the musical is based on Eliot's work, poetry is important to the show, as is the music. “We have extensive rehearsal sessions to learn the melodies and harmonies and specifically the pronunciation and diction,

to make the words and poetry as clear as possible.”

This is the second Lloyd Webber production to be staged at NMACC. In March

Cats, which premiered in London's West End in 1981, is based on T.S. Eliot's 1939 poetry collection Old Possum's Book of Practical Cats. The musical traces the tale of a tribe of cats called Jellicles

Cats is a completely sung-through show and intertwined with dance.



“My earliest influences would have been Gene Kelly, films such as *White Christmas* and all the Disney musical films. When I realised that they were no longer as popular and not made any more, I felt musical theatre was the closest genre I could pursue. I went to a musical theatre school every week for most of my childhood and then to the London Studio Centre where I trained in dance, singing and acting every day for three years,” he shares.

Matt has also been involved with productions such as *Matilda*, *Joseph and the Amazing Technicolor Dreamcoat*, *Chicago*, *Priscilla Queen of the Desert*, *Wicked* and *Starlight Express*. The role of resident director for *Cats* adds a fresh dimension to his work.

Cats will be staged at the Grand Theatre of the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai, from June 17 to 28.



Life in melody Suman Kalyanpur; with Mohammed Rafi. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENTS



A distinct note

Suman Kalyanpur, who passed away recently, faced comparisons and competition with dignity, while showcasing her remarkable versatility

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In Hindi cinema's golden age, when competition was often unfair and musical giants carried bloated egos, Suman Kalyanpur approached singing not as a vehicle for fame but as a pure, spiritual extension of her early love for the arts. Underappreciated even after delivering massive chartbusters, she remained gentle, humble and media-shy.

Born on January 28, 1937, in Dhaka, her family relocated to Bombay in 1943. Music was not her first choice. As a teenager, she was passionate about visual arts. After schooling, she enrolled at the Sir J.J. School of Art to pursue painting.

Her musical training under Pt. Keshav Rao Bhole began after family members noticed her talent when she sang Noor Jehan's songs at home.

Later, Khan Abdul Rehman Khan of the Kirana gharana provided her with a grounding in Hindustani classical music, which was followed by a stint under Master Navrang.

In 1953, when Suman sang at a college function, she impressed the legendary Talat Mahmood, who was the chief guest. Mahmood recommended her name to the recording label HMV, and Suman soon found a

foothold in the fiercely competitive Hindi music industry dominated by the Mangeskar sisters.

While her first film, *Mangu*, was stalled by production delays, she was signed for *Darwaza*. Produced by the literary icon Ismat Chughtai with music by Naushad, the film is remembered for the duet ‘Ek dil do hain talabgaar’, sung by Suman with Talat Mahmood. The newcomer held her own alongside the celebrated singer. Soon, the top composers of the time were eager to work with her, and Suman's duets with Mohammed Rafi became one of the defining features of Hindi film music. In 1958, she married Ramanand Kalyanpur, a Mumbai-based businessman, who was one of her greatest admirers.

In a career spanning three decades, Suman sang in about 100 films across different languages. Her definitive masterpieces include ‘Na tum

hamein jano’ with Hemant Kumar (*Baat Ek Raat Ki*), where her voice flows gently like moonlight over S.D. Burman's minimalist arrangement; Shankar-Jaikishan's pulsating ‘Aaj kal tere mere pyar ke charche’ (*Brahmachari*); Kalyanji-Anandji's playful ‘Na na karte pyar tumhi se’ (*Jab Jab Phool Khile*) with Rafi; Khayyam's melodious ‘Thehriye hosh mein aa loon’ (*Mohabbat Isko Kahte Hain*) and Naushad's tender ‘Mera pyar bhi tu hai’ (*Saathi*) with Mukesh. Suman's flair for ghazal singing, rich with nuances of Urdu, came to the fore in Ghulam Mohammad's ‘Chhipe chhipe se kyun

Though Suman looked up to Lata Mangeshkar as an inspiration, the similarity in their voices remains one of the most fascinating stories in playback history

ho’ (*Shama*). In Roshan's raag Malhar-based ‘Barsat sawan aayo re’ (*Barsat Ki Raat*) Suman showcased her classical prowess.

Though Suman looked up to Lata Mangeshkar as an inspiration, the overlap between their voices is one of the most fascinating stories (radio announcers credited her songs to Lata) in Indian playback history.

In the early 1960s, when Lata had royalty disputes with Rafi and music directors such as S.D. Burman, Suman emerged as a suitable substitute. Their voices bore an uncanny resemblance – high-pitched, crystalline sopranos that defined the era's acoustic ideal.

Simultaneously, Suman achieved recognition in the Marathi non-film music ecosystem too. Collaborating with literary geniuses such as poet Shanta Shelke and composers such as Srinivas Khale, she became a well-known voice of bhavgeet.

Suman Kalyanpur faced comparisons and competition with dignity and gracefully stepped away from active playback singing in the mid-1980s, when Laxmikant-Pyarelal chose to unceremoniously replace her with younger singers. Ironically, her last hit, ‘Zindagi imtihaan leti hai’ (*Naseeb*), was for Laxmikant-Pyarelal.

CALENDAR

Anniversary special

Chennai Fine Arts commemorates the birth anniversary of the mridangam maestro Palghat Mani Iyer on June 10, 6 p.m., at Srinivasa Sastri Hall, Mylapore. On the occasion, the Palghat Mani Iyer award will be presented to senior mridangist Melakaveri K. Balaji. The evening will feature Mahadevan Sankaranarayanan's concert with M.R. Gopinath (violin), Melakaveri K. Balaji (mridangam) and Anirudh Athreya (kanjira).

Music concert

The Music Academy will present Ananth Mysore's vocal concert on June 8, 6 p.m. He will be accompanied by Sreeranjani Muthu Subramanian (violin) and Srihari S. Raman (mridangam). Organised as part of HCL Concerts, it will be held at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

In memory of a stalwart

Madurai Mani Iyer Rasikas Association will present a special listening session on the occasion of the 68th remembrance day of the legendary musician Madurai Mani Iyer. To be held on June 7, 4.25 p.m., it will take place at P.S. High School, Mylapore.

Tamil play

Under the auspices of Chromepet Cultural Academy, S. Sruthi's Naatya Naadha Nataka Sangamam will stage its latest social drama Kandhaveylanin Karunai on June 6, 6.45 p.m. at CCA hall.

